Parts of the data between data domains can be duplicated. Still, because that data is serving a different purpose, it will also be modeled differently. So usually domain boundaries will, at the same time, also be data model boundaries. Because we want to give teams as much autonomy as possible, we are not trying to achieve a single canonical model for the whole organization. We are giving them the freedom to model the data in the way they need it. Besides the source- and consumer-aligned domains, we could also encounter core data domains used across the organization. These usually represent key entities or objects.

When we share the responsibility for data across the organization, we gain tremendous scalability and maintainability. For example, when we want to add new datasets to the mesh, we will be adding a new autonomous node. At the same time, teams that own datasets will be in a comfortable situation. They will own only data that they truly understand.

1.4.2 Data as a product

The second principle is that *data must be viewed as a product*. This calls for an introduction of product thinking (integrated into data management).

Usually, when we talk about data, the first thing that comes to mind is either a file or a table in a database. We often envision a spreadsheet or a series of rows in a file with named columns. Taking this perspective, it is easy to reduce data to technical details. But instead, the more important question is, what gives value to the data from the organization’s point of view? Or reversing this question, what is stopping our data from being turned into valuable decisions?

Without a proper set of descriptions, even the best prepared set of data will not be found and thus no value extracted from it. If it is unknown how current or complete the data might be, this could render it completely useless. That’s why it’s worthwhile to think of data as a product—a larger whole that ultimately makes up the experience of the users who use it.

In our experience, data offered by a data team should follow typical product features like these: